The Susan Smith Tapes

By R.M. Vaughan

SUSAN: Miss Oprah, I hope you still remember me. My name is Susan Smith and I did an evil thing. *(She stops the camera, rewinds for a few seconds, then starts again)* Miss Oprah, I know you still remember me. My name is Susan Smith. Evil things happened to me.

INTRODUCTION

At the age of 23, Susan Smith was convicted for murdering her two sons, 3-year-old Michael and 14-month-old Alexander. The case gained worldwide attention, after she claimed that a black man stole her car and kidnapped her sons. That was a lie.

The defense argued during the sentencing phase of the trial that difficult life circumstances and depression led Susan to a failed suicide attempt, a suicide attempt that resulted in the "unfortunate" deaths of her children. On the night of their deaths, Mrs. Smith parked her car on a steep incline leading to the lake. She let go the hand brake, reconsidered and pulled it up again, then let it go and – in some instinct for survival – jumped from the car, allowing it to roll into the lake, and drowning her children inside. How, many people wonder, was that a suicide attempt?

The jury rejected the death penalty and instead sentenced her to life in prison . . . to remember . . . in a tiny cell with the ghosts of her dead children.

The Susan Smith Tapes by R.M. Vaughan in which the infamous young mother tries to recapture the public's attention by auditioning for talk shows from her prison cell.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

[Smith sets up a video camera on a tripod between herself and the audience]

SUSAN: (Tape 1) Hello, Miss Oprah? I hope you can see me all right. I don't photograph too well. I mean, with these lights and all. And the white – white makes me look fat. Miss Oprah, I'm sending you this tape because I think maybe

you never got near my last letter. It came back all bent up and ragged like a worn-out mop and I don't like to think you'd treat a heartfelt letter that way. Funny thing was, when I make the word 'heart' I don't spell it out h-e-a-r-t but I draw it directly on the paper, like a valentines heart (draws heart with finger in the air), I always done that, since I don't remember when – and, well, when my last letter came back, somebody, well, somebody mean, took my letter an cut out every one of my signature hearts. Why do people do these things? Guess some folks can't forgive and forget.

Miss Oprah, I'm scared. So what, everybody's scared. I learned that here. But I'm scared of history. What are people gonna say about me in the future times? Miss Oprah, a lot of untrue stories have been said about me and I need to have my time to make my say. I was a good mother to Michael and Alex, right up till the bad time. Those boys was always clean and dressed sharp and they never went hungry one minute of their lives. That is my truth. Can't nobody take that achievement away from me.

Momma still talks about the day you came down from Chicago to visit the lake where my boys went to Glory. I wish you hadn't brought your cameramen to the lake, though, because it's such a pretty lake and now the whole world only sees the bad side of the location. Maybe you and me can work together to make that old lake shine again. I am good on TV, I come across natural. (End of Tape 1)

SUSAN: (Tape 2) Mr. Springer, my name is Susan Smith. You did a show on me a few years back, and I'm just saying thank you again. I guess you can tell I'm still in prison. I gained some weight since you saw me last, from the sittin' all day.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Kinda a relief, just to let go. If I'm healthy, I thank the Good Lord for my fortune.

Mr. Springer, when the incident I done involving my two boys came out, there was a whole team of folks at the county District Attorney office workin' day and night to fix me for the electric chair but they lost. Listen to me! Of course they lost, 'cause here I am alive and jawin' away like a TV talk show person myself. I saw you done a whole program on the badness of the death penalty, and I was thinking you should do another one because the issue is very large in the minds of many people. I can help out, if you like.

When my boys was killed, I took responsibility. I was slow to it, I admit, but eventually I come around to the truth. People say the bet ways I can pay back for my boys is for me to go on over to the other side myself, but there's more than one way to make amends. I want to come on your show and tell young mothers my story, so's they can learn from my example. If the State of South Carolina up and hauled me to the electric chair, they ony get a one-shot deal on the example of my life. That's a sinful waste of the human spirit.

I been practicin' my set piece, and now I would ask you to hear it out. (She reads from a sheet of paper). My name is Susan Smith, and I have experienced great tragedy in my life. The death of a child is every mother's worst all-time day and nighttime nightmare. The death of two children is double that plus some traumas nobody can name. I am here today to tell all you kind people that human life is precious and unreplaceable. I know because I will ever hear my baby boys' voices again. I will never see them goin' off for the first day of school, never help them with learnin' their times tables, never go down to the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

front porch to meet their girlfriends and never hold their own babies in my arms. Life is cruel and beautiful too, but the cruellest day in the world came when circumstances situated to take my babies from me. Even after I am dead and gone I can still hold my head up high to the sky above and say no matter what I am a mother, and that is a no-refund deal. (She sets the paper down) What do you think?

Mr. Springer, I don't deserve to die. My boys and me, we had a special bond. We was like people who can talk to each other without saying a word, them gifted people with angel powers. I couldn't walk away from that power, Mr. Springer, nobody in the world could. My mother love was too strong. Them boys woulda spent the rest of their lives wondering why they was so bad that their momma put herself at the bottom of the lake rather than be with them. I would have put a curse on my own children had I gone to Glory before my time. I admit to my shame I wanted to commit suicide, but I did not leave my boys abandoned, I did not take the easy road and leave my babies to make on in the world without a mother.

I made a choice, for my babies. That's what folks is afraid of, the deep-down feelin' they got that they don't wanna hear talkin' to them – the voice that says Susan Smith done right, horrible right, but right. It's too hard to bear. I made a choice, in a second, in a half a minute, and it moved the world to tears. Anybody wants to come kill me better look around and ask hisself when was the last time he sacrificed like I sacrificed for my babies. Most people won't even put a sick dog down, they's so selfish. I am not afraid to cry on Wednesday so I can smile on Sunday. All my life, I have always looked to the horizon, not the trail. Sometimes I think I am the bravest woman I know. (End of Tape 2)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SUSAN: (Tape 3) You may not remember me – but my name is Susan Smith. I never wanted this kind of national attention, but I got it anyway, so I may's well get in my say in the story. Miss Walters, I believe life is about decisions. Have you ever made a decision that took only a couple of minutes but changed the rest of your day? I did. If you want to show this video on the 20/2 show, I won't mind.

When I left my home on Tuesday, October 25, 1994, I was very emotionally distraught. I was a girl in a woman's body. I couldn't sort our my needs. I understand that now. My boys – Michael, he's three, and Alex, the baby, he's fourteen months – got in the back of the car like always. Michael says, "Lock the doors, Momma!" – he always said that. It was our automobile safety game. I showed him how to fix his baby brother into the car seat so that he was safe and snug as a Eskimo papoose.

We drove around for four hours, the boys were asleep. I wanted to see the lake, the lake is so alive. If you go at night, you can watch the catfish jump for bugs and it makes you feel energetic. The lake's full of catfish. But lately folks don't eat them like they used to, they say the lake's poisoned forever. People are full of hate.

I say by the side of the lake while the boys slept and snored and talked baby dream talk to each other and I thought to myself, I want to die. It just came over me, the death pull. I'm like that, just get taken away by emotions. I felt I couldn't be a good mom any more. But I didn't want my children to grow up without a mom. I had to end our lives to protect us from any grief or harm.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

The car when in no trouble. The mud around the lake is so slick. Michael woke up for a minute. "Where we goin', Momma?" He never said another word, smart as can be. "I love y'all! I love y'all! I love y'all!" He knew.

My name is Susan Smith. Evil things happened to me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: R.M. Vaughan
Book: The Monster Trilogy: Plays
ISBN: 978-1552451328
Publisher: Coach House Press
Date (Month/Year): 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
NIETOC
KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY